



Comments for Thelonious

First off, this is a great paper! Congratulations. I generally err on the side of providing more comments rather than fewer as that's my personal preference. I left my comments below – hope this helps!

If anything is unclear, feel free to leave a comment in the doc (and tag me) and we can go back and forth.

Major

I would really try to make the identification strategy extra clear immediately. This is really crucial for the reader to understand. I also would define what exactly government fragmentation means immediately the first time it's introduced. This is a good star, but it could be expanded:

“The intuition of this approach is that counties with greater government fragmentation in 1967 lead to greater sorting between neighborhoods that increases segregation but is unrelated to individual outcomes.”

What does government fragmentation mean, exactly? In the background, it might even be helpful to include a dedicated section on fragmentation, explaining how it's defined with some accompanying visualization illustrating fragmentation (e.g., an example map of a fragmented and non-fragmented county).

The background section does a nice job of summarizing past studies, but you could consider making it a bit more narrative to set up the contribution of the paper. I like the strategy of thinking of a lit review as a guided argument about what we do know, what we don't know yet, and what the present study w.

I think the CenSoc component here is really nicely done! I like the decision to focus on the birth cohorts of 1905-1920. Reviewers may ask you to re-weight on observables in the 1940 Census, but in our experience that hasn't made a difference to our results for past studies.

Is there temporal variation in the local government fragmentation over time or is this measure fairly constant? This seems important to consider, as your data on local government fragmentation is cross-sectional from 1967. Does this have any implications for your results? I think you touched on this a bit, but would be helpful to make this more clear.

I would consider adding a paragraph or subsection explicitly discussing limitations and directions for future work in this area. I think here you could discuss stuff like double-truncation,

weaknesses of your IV approach, if you expect effect sizes would be smaller/larger for more contemporary cohorts, etc.

I know this is a draft, but I would recommend going through the paper again carefully before submitting to smooth out the writing (it's a bit uneven across sections). You want this to be quite polished before you submit, I think!

Minor:

A few small points while reading through:

“10-point increase in racial segregation” - is this some segregation index?

“It is well known that the Numident data suffer from the problem of left and right censoring of the data, known as double truncation.” — A bit technical, but censoring and truncation are different. So this should read left and right truncation. [[Description of difference](#)]

Double-check the math here: “This means that those born in 1905 are observed between the ages of 85-100 years old”

“This matching procedure may be particularly selective for unmarried women, fortunately the Numident data contain parents last names that can be used to link women who have undergone name changes (Breen et al. 2023)” — This needs to be clarified a bit and explained more clearly, perhaps as a footnote.

Consider citing this paper when discussing IV assumptions:
<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/00491241241235900>

“My final analytic sample consists of (N = 2, 152, 370) individuals residing in 1, 774(N × T = 4, 678) counties at their time of death over three decades from 1980-2000 (Table A1 Secondary Appendix).” — I didn't entirely understand the N X T

Only need to say “I follow Cutler and Glaeser (1997)” once

Define Tiebout mechanism the first time it's introduced

Fix citations not compiling correctly [@ signs]

I found citations in the middle of sentences occasionally to be a bit distracting

I wouldn't do a main appendix and a secondary appendix. And I was a bit confused that the figures for the main text were in an appendix. (Ignore if this is a journal convention that I'm not familiar with)

Figures:

Fig 1

- I didn't understand what the x-axis mean exactly ("Log(N Governments) + Revenue Share")
- Can you clarify in the caption how county similarity is measured

Fig 2

- Can you say what adjusted means here, exactly? I forgot from the text (and reviewers may too)

Fig 4

- Is this adjusted or unadjusted?
- For this figure and others, consider shifting "Change in years of life" → "Change in life expectancy"

Fig A1

- Drop gridlines and background panel